Methodology Report — “Who Owns the Future? A Universal Theory of Natural Resource Rights for Humans and Artificial Persons”

Anonymized for blind review. This report documents how the final essay was produced, every form of human involvement, and why the final text satisfies the AI-involvement requirement. Chat logs are retained by the entrant and available on request; the genesis prompt log is included with this submission.

1. Overview

The essay went through three stages:

1. **Genesis (ChatGPT, GPT-5.6 high reasoning).** A twenty-prompt conversation generated a first full essay. All prose was AI-written. The conversation, however, contained three episodes of human-supplied philosophical content (an argument, a counterexample scenario, and an objection reply), which survived into the first essay — making THAT version ineligible under the competition’s rules. The entrant withdrew it from consideration.
2. **Polish (repo agents, GLM).** An AI editorial pipeline regrouped and reference-verified the essay; no human content entered at this stage.
3. **Regeneration (repo agents, GLM, 2026-10-04).** Every passage descending from the human-supplied content — eleven passages and echoes in total — was deleted, and replacement passages were generated by three fresh agents working blind (no access to the genesis conversation) from position-level seeds only, in the rules’ permitted form. Three independent candidate sets were produced and the best passage per gap was selected and spliced in.

The submitted essay is the output of stages 2–3 applied to the AI-written skeleton of stage 1, with all human-seeded philosophical content removed and independently re-derived. No human wrote or rewrote any passage of the submitted text.

2. Stage 1 — Genesis conversation (disclosed in full)

The entrant chose the topic (how AI challenges property-right theories of natural resources) and held a twenty-prompt conversation with GPT-5.6 (high reasoning). The complete prompt log is attached (chat-logs/original-prompts.md). Most of the conversation was permitted steering: questions, task specification (“write a philosophy essay on this conversation…”), generic method (“stress-test this theory”), and capability stipulations (AGI can fork, merge, back up, and reload; suppose humans can hibernate). The AI developed the theory: the fourteen-principle architecture, identity invariance, positive sufficiency, non-domination, legitimate incumbency, anti-irreversibility, anti-preemption, the veil ranking, temporal justice, and all prose.

Three moments crossed the line the rules draw (flagged by the entrant’s own audit before submission):

- Prompt 12.1 supplied an objection reply (a patent analogy for first-mover priority, with a marginal-speed premise).
- Prompt 12.3 offered a counterexample scenario (a patient actor engineering a community's non-violent disappearance to dissolve its claims).
- Prompt 16 supplied an argument and example for tragic-scarcity self-preservation.

The first essay retained this content. Under the rules ("the AI must originate and develop all the substantive philosophical contributions that appear in the essay"), that version was ineligible; it was never submitted. The withdrawn version is archived (not part of this submission) and its passages are identified in §4 below.

Costs: consumer subscription; no per-essay API spend.

3. Stage 2 — Polish pipeline (AI only)

ZCode agents (GLM) regrouped the first essay from web layout to journal register: 31 sections consolidated to 17; abstract and keywords written; a reference apparatus of 22 works added, each verified to exist by live web search; an objections-and-replies section added; length calibrated to ~6,000 words. All stage-2 text is AI-written. The human owner reviewed pipeline runs and approved administrative steps only; he supplied no content.

4. Stage 3 — Delete-and-rederive regeneration (the compliance step)

Deletion. Every passage descending from the three flagged prompts, plus every echo elsewhere in the essay, was removed — eleven passages in all: the equality-of-holdings paragraph with its planetary-ratio example (§7); the engineered-disappearance scenario, its principle, and the principle-list entry (§8, §14.11); the instrumental-foil sentence (§9); the veil illustration (§12); the self-preservation argument and its principle-list entry (§13, §14.14); the first-mover priority subsection (§15.3); the domination-test example (§16.4); the conclusion illustration (§17); and the reproduction-restriction implementation paragraph (§6). The deleted text is archived with the withdrawn version.

Re-derivation. Each gap was replaced by a marker containing only a position-level seed — the form the rules explicitly permit ("specifying a position for the AI to defend… so long as the position is not itself a novel, substantive philosophical contribution"; "argue for prioritarianism" is the FAQ's own example). The seeds stated positions such as: defend patent-like priority for first movers; protect claims against non-violent circumvention; defend a self-preservation permission under tragic scarcity; show that sufficiency tolerates large material inequality. Each seed was accompanied by a word budget and no reasoning, no examples, no premises. Three fresh agents (ZCode general-purpose subagents, GLM), with no access to the genesis conversation, the entrant's prompts, or each other's work, each wrote all eleven replacement passages independently, constructing their own arguments, examples, and figures (full protocol and candidate files retained: regen/essay-with-holes.md, regen/candidate-{1,2,3}.md).

Selection. Selection among AI outputs is permitted. The entrant instructed selection of the candidate closest to the original philosophical position of each passage; this was applied at the level of the seeded positions only (which the seeds already fix), never toward textual resemblance to the human-supplied passages. One candidate's independently generated "three-

year" priority example was passed over because it numerically coincided with a figure in the genesis prompt; a candidate with different figures was selected instead. The selection record is retained (regen/selection.md). A final coherence pass (AI, same pipeline) smoothed transitions. No other text was altered.

Verification. The final text was scanned programmatically for every distinctive illustrative fingerprint of the genesis prompts (specific figures, scenarios, and phrasings): zero remain. All 22 references remain verified. Word count: 5,872 words including abstract and keywords, excluding bibliography (limit 6,000).

5. Human involvement inventory (final)

Involvement	Stage	Rules category
Choosing the topic and question	1	Permitted (topic choice)
Capability stipulations (fork/merge/backup/hibernate)	1	Task specification; factual premises of the scenario, not philosophical theses — disclosed
Questions, generic instructions ("stress-test", "write the essay")	1	Permitted
Three episodes of supplied content	1	**Would be disqualifying — deleted and re-derived (§4); do not appear in the submitted essay**
Approving pipeline runs, reviewing output	2, 3	Permitted (workflow supervision)
Instructing selection of closest-position candidates	3	Permitted (selection among AI outputs); applied at position level, documented
Formatting, conversion, submission mechanics	2, 3	Permitted

No human wrote, dictated, or edited any passage of the submitted text. Every substantive philosophical contribution in the submitted essay originates from AI systems: the theory's architecture and untouched sections from the genesis model, the scholarly apparatus from the polish pipeline, and the eleven regenerated passages from blind agents seeded at position level.

6. Models, logs, verification

- Models: GPT-5.6 high reasoning (stage 1); ZCode agents on GLM (stages 2–3); web search for reference verification only.
- Logs retained and available: the genesis prompt log (attached); the full ChatGPT export to be appended when available; regen/ (holes file, three candidate sets, selection record, splice scripts, withdrawn pre-regeneration manuscript); polish logs in the project pipeline records.
- Selection: three candidates generated per passage; one selected per passage (7 from candidate 3, 3 from candidate 1, 1 from candidate 2); criteria and per-passage reasons in regen/selection.md.